

Chapter 5 — Print Culture and the Modern World

The one-line point: Print did not merely make books cheaper — it **changed the relationship between ordinary people and authority**. Once anyone could put an argument into a thousand copies, **the Church could no longer decide what could be believed, and the state could no longer decide what could be said**. That is why a miller was executed for reading, why an Index of Prohibited Books existed, why the Vernacular Press Act was passed — and why Gandhi said the fight for swaraj was **first** a fight for the freedom of the press.

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Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → World History + Social and cultural history of colonial India
Sub-discipline	History of communication and the public sphere · religion · social reform
Period	AD 594 – 1947
Prelims (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ Diamond Sutra, Gutenberg, the 1450–1550 figures, the Index, chapbooks, the Vernacular Press Act, Rammohun Roy's papers, Amar Jiban, Gulamgiri — all clean factual items
Mains (GS Paper I)	★ ★ ★ "effect on the society"; social reform movements ; the making of public opinion ; nationalism's infrastructure
Also feeds	★ ★ ★ ★ GS2 Polity (freedom of speech and the press — Art. 19(1)(a)) ; censorship; the origins of the Indian public sphere), Indian Society ★ ★ ★ ★ (women's education, caste protest, Phule/Ambekar/Periyar), Ethics/Essay ★ ★ ★ ★ (technology and social change; misinformation; who controls information), GS1 Society ★ ★ ★ ★
Weightage	★ ★ ★ — and disproportionately useful for Polity and Essay
Overlaps with	★ ★ ★ Class 9 Ch.1 (the abolition of censorship in 1789; print and the Revolution), Ch.1 of this book (press freedom as <i>the</i> liberal demand; the Grimms), Ch.2 (nationalist newspapers, Tilak), Class 8 Ch.7 (reform debates)

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Trace print from China, Japan and Korea to Europe, with dates.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Explain why woodblock print reached Europe only after 1295.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Describe Gutenberg's press and what he adapted it from.** ★ ★ ★ ★
- ☐ **Give the 1450–1550 and sixteenth-century print figures.** ★ ★ ★
- ☐ ★ ★ ★ ★ **Explain how a HEARING public became a READING public — and why the line blurred.**
- ☐ **Explain print's role in the Protestant Reformation.** ★ ★ ★ ★
- ☐ ★ ★ ★ ★ **Explain why people FEARED print — Menocchio, the Index, Erasmus.**
- ☐ **Describe the reading mania — chapbooks, Bibliothèque Bleue, almanacs, the periodical press.** ★ ★ ★

- ☐ ★★★★★ Give the **THREE arguments** linking print culture to the French Revolution — **and NCERT's qualification.**
- ☐ Describe **nineteenth-century new readers** — children, women, workers. ★★★
- ☐ Describe **Indian manuscript culture** and why manuscripts were not widely used. ★★★
- ☐ Narrate the **coming of print to India** and the Hickey episode. ★★★
- ☐ ★★★★★ Explain how **print shaped religious and reform debates** — Hindu, Muslim and the vernacular press.
- ☐ ★★★★★ Explain what print meant to **WOMEN, to the POOR, and to REFORMERS** — NCERT asks this directly.
- ☐ ★★★★★ Explain **colonial censorship** from 1798 to the Vernacular Press Act to 1942.

1 The First Printed Books — East Asia

★★★★★ *"The earliest kind of print technology was developed in CHINA, JAPAN and KOREA. This was a system of **HAND PRINTING**. From AD 594 onwards, books in China were printed by **RUBBING PAPER** — also invented there — **AGAINST THE INKED SURFACE OF WOODBLOCKS**. As both sides of the thin, porous sheet could not be printed, the traditional Chinese ★ 'ACCORDION BOOK' was **FOLDED AND STITCHED AT THE SIDE**."*

Word: ★ **Calligraphy** — the art of beautiful and stylised writing. *"Superbly skilled craftsmen could duplicate, with remarkable accuracy, the beauty of calligraphy."*

China — the state as the great printer

"THE IMPERIAL STATE IN CHINA WAS, FOR A VERY LONG TIME, THE MAJOR PRODUCER OF PRINTED MATERIAL."
 "China possessed a HUGE BUREAUCRATIC SYSTEM which recruited its personnel through CIVIL SERVICE EXAMINATIONS. TEXTBOOKS FOR THIS EXAMINATION WERE PRINTED IN VAST NUMBERS UNDER THE SPONSORSHIP OF THE IMPERIAL STATE.
 From the SIXTEENTH CENTURY, the number of examination candidates went up AND THAT INCREASED THE VOLUME OF PRINT."
 |
 BY THE SEVENTEENTH CENTURY -- "as URBAN CULTURE BLOOMED, THE USES OF PRINT DIVERSIFIED. Print was NO LONGER USED JUST BY SCHOLAR-OFFICIALS."
 - MERCHANTS used print "as they COLLECTED TRADE INFORMATION"
 - "READING INCREASINGLY BECAME A LEISURE ACTIVITY"
 - the new readership preferred "FICTIONAL NARRATIVES, POETRY, AUTOBIOGRAPHIES, ANTHOLOGIES of literary masterpieces, and ROMANTIC PLAYS"
 - "RICH WOMEN BEGAN TO READ, and MANY WOMEN BEGAN PUBLISHING THEIR POETRY AND PLAYS. Wives of scholar-officials published their works and COURTESANS WROTE ABOUT THEIR LIVES."
 |
 LATE NINETEENTH CENTURY -- "WESTERN PRINTING TECHNIQUES AND MECHANICAL PRESSES WERE IMPORTED as Western powers established their outposts. SHANGHAI became the hub of the new print culture, catering to the WESTERN-STYLE SCHOOLS."

🎯 ★ ★ ★ Notice what drove Chinese print for a thousand years: an **EXAMINATION SYSTEM**. The state printed textbooks in vast numbers because it recruited officials by exam — so **the world's first great print industry existed to serve civil service aspirants**. (A fact you may find either encouraging or ominous.) ★ And note the direction of change: print began as an instrument of the **STATE** and became, by the seventeenth century, an instrument of **LEISURE, COMMERCE** and — **significantly** — **WOMEN'S AUTHORSHIP**. That drift from official to popular is the pattern the whole chapter follows.

JP 1.1 Print in Japan

Fact	Detail
★ ★ Arrival	" BUDDHIST MISSIONARIES FROM CHINA introduced hand-printing technology into Japan around AD 768–770"
★ ★ ★ The oldest book	"The oldest Chinese book , printed in AD 868, is the Buddhist DIAMOND SUTRA , containing six sheets of text and woodcut illustrations "
What else was printed	"Pictures were printed on textiles, playing cards and paper money "
★ In medieval Japan	" poets and prose writers were regularly published, and BOOKS WERE CHEAP AND ABUNDANT "
★ ★ The Tripitaka Koreana	Korean Buddhist scriptures of the mid-13th century , engraved on about 80,000 woodblocks ; on the UNESCO Memory of the World Register, 2007
★ ★ The Jikji	"among the world's oldest existing books printed with MOVABLE METAL TYPE ", on Zen Buddhism , printed in late 14th-century Korea ; the second volume is in the National Library of France ; on the UNESCO register, 2001

★ ★ Edo (later Tokyo), late eighteenth century: "illustrated collections of paintings depicted **an elegant urban culture, involving artists, courtesans, and teahouse gatherings. Libraries and bookstores were packed with hand-printed material** — books on **women, musical instruments, calculations, tea ceremony, flower arrangements, proper etiquette, cooking and famous places.**"

Box 1 — Kitagawa Utamaro, born in Edo in **1753**, known for ★ *ukiyo ("pictures of the floating world") — "depiction of **ORDINARY HUMAN EXPERIENCES, especially URBAN ones.**" ★ ★ "These prints travelled to contemporary US and Europe and **INFLUENCED ARTISTS LIKE MANET, MONET AND VAN GOGH.**" The process: publishers like **Tsutaya Juzaburo** identified subjects and commissioned artists who drew the theme in outline; a **woodblock carver pasted the drawing on a block and carved it** — ⚠️ *"**In the process, THE ORIGINAL DRAWING WOULD BE DESTROYED and ONLY PRINTS WOULD SURVIVE.**"* 🎯 Two things worth carrying away. First, ★ **the influence ran EAST to WEST** — Japanese prints shaped European Impressionism, which is a useful corrective to any assumption that cultural influence flowed only one way. Second, the original was **destroyed to make the copies**: in print, **the copy is not a lesser version of the original — it replaces it**. That inversion is the whole difference between manuscript and print culture.

2 Print Comes to Europe ★★ ★

THE ROUTE

"For centuries, SILK AND SPICES from China flowed into Europe THROUGH THE SILK ROUTE."

"In the ELEVENTH CENTURY, CHINESE PAPER REACHED EUROPE via the same route. PAPER MADE POSSIBLE THE PRODUCTION OF MANUSCRIPTS, carefully written by SCRIBES."

1295 -- "MARCO POLO, a great explorer, RETURNED TO ITALY after many years of exploration in China... China already had the technology of WOODBLOCK PRINTING.

MARCO POLO BROUGHT THIS KNOWLEDGE BACK WITH HIM."

"Now ITALIANS began producing books with woodblocks, and soon the technology SPREAD TO OTHER PARTS OF EUROPE."

THE CLASS DIVIDE IN BOOKS

"LUXURY EDITIONS were still HANDWRITTEN ON VERY EXPENSIVE VELLUM, meant for ARISTOCRATIC CIRCLES and RICH MONASTIC LIBRARIES WHICH SCOFFED AT PRINTED BOOKS AS 'CHEAP VULGARITIES'.

MERCHANTS AND STUDENTS in the university towns bought the CHEAPER PRINTED COPIES."

Word: ★ Vellum — a parchment made from the skin of animals.

Why handwriting could not keep up — ★★ ★:

- "booksellers all over Europe began **exporting books** to many different countries. **BOOK FAIRS** were held at different places."
- ★ *"**Scribes** or skilled handwriters were **no longer solely employed by wealthy or influential patrons but increasingly BY BOOKSELLERS** as well. **MORE THAN 50 SCRIBES** often worked for **ONE BOOKSELLER**."*
- ★★ *"**But the production of handwritten manuscripts COULD NOT SATISFY the ever-increasing demand. COPYING WAS AN EXPENSIVE, LABORIOUS AND TIME-CONSUMING BUSINESS. Manuscripts were FRAGILE, AWKWARD TO HANDLE, and COULD NOT BE CARRIED AROUND OR READ EASILY. THEIR CIRCULATION THEREFORE REMAINED LIMITED.**"*
- "By the **early fifteenth century**, woodblocks were widely used in Europe to print **textiles, playing cards, and religious pictures with simple, brief texts.**"

🖨️ 2.1 Gutenberg and the printing press — ★★★★★

Element	Detail
Where and when	"The breakthrough occurred at STRASBOURG, GERMANY , where JOHANN GUTENBERG developed the first-known printing press in the 1430s"
★★★★ What he adapted	"From his childhood he had seen WINE AND OLIVE PRESSES . Subsequently he learnt the art of polishing stones, became a MASTER GOLDSMITH , and acquired the expertise to create LEAD MOULDS used for making trinkets . Drawing on this knowledge, Gutenberg ADAPTED EXISTING TECHNOLOGY to design his innovation. THE OLIVE PRESS PROVIDED THE MODEL FOR THE PRINTING PRESS, and MOULDS WERE USED FOR CASTING THE METAL TYPES for the letters of the alphabet "
★★★ The system	"By 1448, Gutenberg perfected the system. ★ The FIRST BOOK he printed was THE BIBLE . About 180 COPIES were printed and IT TOOK THREE YEARS to produce them. BY THE STANDARDS OF THE TIME THIS WAS FAST PRODUCTION. "*
★★ Movable type	"Gutenberg developed metal types for each of the 26 characters of the Roman alphabet and devised a way of MOVING THEM AROUND so as to compose different words . This came to be known as the ★ MOVEABLE TYPE PRINTING MACHINE , and it remained the BASIC PRINT TECHNOLOGY OVER THE NEXT 300 YEARS "
★★★ The speed	"The Gutenberg press could print 250 SHEETS on one side PER HOUR "

Word: ★ Platen — "in letterpress printing, a **BOARD WHICH IS PRESSED ONTO THE BACK OF THE PAPER** to get the impression from the type. At one time a wooden board; later made of steel." Also ★ Compositor — the person who composes the text for printing; ★ Galley — the metal frame in which types are laid and the text composed.

🎯 ★★★★★ Gutenberg invented nothing from nothing, and that is the point worth making. He took **the olive press** (from a farming childhood), **stone polishing and goldsmithing** (his trade), and **lead moulds for trinkets** — and combined them. ★ **Innovation here is RECOMBINATION, not invention from scratch.** (Compare Ford adapting a slaughterhouse conveyor to cars in Ch.3 — the same move.)

★★★★★ And the crucial qualification most students miss:

*"The new technology **DID NOT ENTIRELY DISPLACE** the existing art of producing books by hand. In fact, **printed books AT FIRST CLOSELY RESEMBLED THE WRITTEN MANUSCRIPTS** in appearance and layout. **THE METAL LETTERS IMITATED THE ORNAMENTAL HANDWRITTEN STYLES**. Borders were **illuminated by hand** with foliage and other patterns, and **illustrations were painted**. ★ **In the books printed for the rich, SPACE FOR DECORATION WAS KEPT BLANK** on the printed page. Each purchaser could **CHOOSE THE DESIGN** and **DECIDE ON THE PAINTING SCHOOL** that would do the illustrations."*

On Gutenberg's Bible: *"No two copies were the same. **EVERY PAGE OF EACH COPY WAS DIFFERENT...** ★★ **ELITES EVERYWHERE PREFERRED THIS LACK OF UNIFORMITY: WHAT THEY POSSESSED THEN COULD BE CLAIMED AS UNIQUE, FOR NO ONE ELSE OWNED A COPY THAT WAS EXACTLY THE SAME.**"* Gutenberg **printed the text in black**, leaving spaces where colour could be filled in later — the colour serving both to **decorate the page** and to **highlight the holy words**. 🎯 ★★★★★ A brand-new technology imitating the thing it replaces is a recurring pattern — and here it reveals a social fact: **the rich valued a book precisely for NOT being identical to anyone else's**. Uniformity, the whole advantage of print, was at first a defect to be concealed. (The same instinct explains why Victorian elites preferred handmade goods in Ch.4.)

★★★ The print explosion	
1450–1550	"printing presses were set up in most countries of Europe " — printers from Germany travelled to other countries , seeking work and helping start new presses
★★ Second half of the fifteenth century	20 MILLION copies of printed books flooding European markets
★★ Sixteenth century	about 200 MILLION copies

★★★ *"**This shift from HAND PRINTING to MECHANICAL PRINTING led to THE PRINT REVOLUTION.**"*

3 The Print Revolution and Its Impact ★★★★★

★★★★★ The definition to quote: *"**What was the print revolution? It was NOT JUST a development, a new way of producing books; IT TRANSFORMED THE LIVES OF PEOPLE, CHANGING THEIR RELATIONSHIP TO INFORMATION AND KNOWLEDGE, AND WITH INSTITUTIONS AND AUTHORITIES. It influenced popular perceptions and OPENED UP NEW WAYS OF LOOKING AT THINGS.**"*

📖 3.1 A new reading public — ★★★★★ the hearing/reading transition

THE MECHANICAL FACT

"Printing **REDUCED THE COST** of books. The **TIME AND LABOUR** required to produce each book **CAME DOWN**, and **MULTIPLE COPIES** could be produced with greater ease."

THE OLD WORLD

"Earlier, **READING WAS RESTRICTED TO THE ELITES**. **COMMON PEOPLE** LIVED IN A WORLD OF ORAL CULTURE. They **HEARD** sacred texts read out, **BALLADS** recited, and **FOLK TALES** narrated.

KNOWLEDGE WAS TRANSFERRED ORALLY. **PEOPLE COLLECTIVELY HEARD** A STORY, OR SAW A PERFORMANCE... **THEY DID NOT READ A BOOK INDIVIDUALLY AND SILENTLY.**"

"**IF EARLIER THERE WAS A HEARING PUBLIC, NOW A READING PUBLIC CAME INTO BEING.**"

BUT THE TRANSITION WAS NOT SIMPLE

"Books could be read **ONLY BY THE LITERATE**, and **THE RATES OF LITERACY** in most European countries **WERE VERY LOW TILL THE TWENTIETH CENTURY**. How, then, could publishers persuade the common people to welcome the printed book?"

THE SOLUTION

"they had to keep in mind **THE WIDER REACH** of the printed work: **EVEN THOSE WHO DID NOT READ COULD CERTAINLY ENJOY LISTENING TO BOOKS BEING READ OUT.**

So printers began publishing **POPULAR BALLADS AND FOLK TALES**, and such books would be **PROFUSELY ILLUSTRATED WITH PICTURES**. These were then **SUNG AND RECITED AT GATHERINGS IN VILLAGES AND IN TAVERNS IN TOWNS.**"

"**ORAL CULTURE THUS ENTERED PRINT AND PRINTED MATERIAL WAS ORALLY TRANSMITTED. THE LINE THAT SEPARATED THE ORAL AND READING CULTURES BECAME BLURRED. AND THE HEARING PUBLIC AND READING PUBLIC BECAME INTERMINGLED.**"

Words: ★ **Ballad** — a historical account or folk tale in verse, usually sung or recited. ★
Taverns — places where people gathered to drink alcohol, to be served food, and to meet friends and exchange news.

🎧 ★★★★★ This section answers the objection that always arises: "how could print matter in a society that could not read?" The answer is that **print did not require universal literacy** — it required **ONE literate person per gathering**. A ballad printed in London, carried by a pedlar, and read aloud in a tavern reaches a hundred people who cannot read a word. ★ **Literacy rates understate print's reach by an enormous margin**, and the same mechanism explains the **reading-aloud in salons and coffee-houses before the French Revolution** (Class 9 Ch.1) and the **calendars hung in Indian tea shops** (Ch.4 §6).

🏠 3.2 Religious debates and the fear of print — ★★★★★

"Print created the possibility of WIDE CIRCULATION OF IDEAS, and introduced A NEW WORLD OF DEBATE AND DISCUSSION. ★★ EVEN THOSE WHO DISAGREED WITH ESTABLISHED AUTHORITIES COULD NOW PRINT AND CIRCULATE THEIR IDEAS. Through the printed message, they could **persuade people to think differently, and MOVE THEM TO ACTION.**"*

And immediately, the fear:

★★★ *"NOT EVERYONE WELCOMED the printed book, and THOSE WHO DID ALSO HAD FEARS about it. Many were apprehensive of the effects that **easier access to the printed word** could have on people's minds. **It was feared that IF THERE WAS NO CONTROL over what was printed and read then REBELLIOUS AND IRRELIGIOUS THOUGHTS MIGHT SPREAD. If that happened THE AUTHORITY OF 'VALUABLE' LITERATURE WOULD BE DESTROYED.** Expressed by **religious authorities and monarchs, as well as many writers and artists, this anxiety was the basis of widespread criticism.**"*

✚ Martin Luther and the Reformation — ★★★★★

1517 -- "the religious reformer MARTIN LUTHER wrote NINETY FIVE THESES criticising many of the practices and rituals of the ROMAN CATHOLIC CHURCH. A printed copy of this was POSTED ON A CHURCH DOOR IN WITTENBERG. IT CHALLENGED THE CHURCH TO DEBATE HIS IDEAS."

"Luther's writings were IMMEDIATELY REPRODUCED IN VAST NUMBERS AND READ WIDELY. THIS LED TO A DIVISION WITHIN THE CHURCH AND TO THE BEGINNING OF THE PROTESTANT REFORMATION."

"Luther's translation of the NEW TESTAMENT SOLD 5,000 COPIES WITHIN A FEW WEEKS and A SECOND EDITION APPEARED WITHIN THREE MONTHS."

LUTHER'S OWN VERDICT:
"PRINTING IS THE ULTIMATE GIFT OF GOD AND THE GREATEST ONE."

"Several scholars, in fact, think that PRINT BROUGHT ABOUT A NEW INTELLECTUAL ATMOSPHERE AND HELPED SPREAD THE NEW IDEAS THAT LED TO THE REFORMATION."

Word: ★ **Protestant Reformation** — "a sixteenth-century movement to reform the Catholic Church dominated by Rome. Martin Luther was one of the main Protestant reformers."

🔥 3.3 Print and dissent — Menocchio ★★★★★

*"Print and popular religious literature **stimulated many DISTINCTIVE INDIVIDUAL INTERPRETATIONS OF FAITH even among little-educated working people.** In the sixteenth century, ★★ **MENOCCHIO, A MILLER IN ITALY, began to read books that were available in his locality. He REINTERPRETED THE MESSAGE OF THE BIBLE and FORMULATED A VIEW OF GOD AND CREATION THAT ENRAGED THE ROMAN CATHOLIC CHURCH.** When the Roman Church began its **INQUISITION** to repress heretical ideas, ⚠️ **Menocchio was HAULED UP TWICE AND ULTIMATELY EXECUTED.**"*

★★★ *"The Roman Church, **troubled by such effects of popular readings and questionings of faith, IMPOSED SEVERE CONTROLS OVER PUBLISHERS AND BOOKSELLERS** and began to maintain **AN INDEX OF PROHIBITED BOOKS FROM 1558.**"*

Words: ★ **Inquisition** — a former Roman Catholic court for identifying and punishing heretics. ★ **Heretical** — "beliefs which do not follow the accepted teachings of the Church. In medieval times, **HERESY WAS SEEN AS A THREAT TO THE RIGHT OF THE CHURCH TO DECIDE ON WHAT SHOULD BE BELIEVED** and what should not."

🎯 ★★★★★ **Menocchio is the single best illustration in the chapter and worth telling in full in an answer.** A **millor** — not a scholar, not a priest — read what was locally available, **thought for himself about God and Creation, and was executed for it.** ★ **What the Church could not tolerate was not a rival theology but the fact that an ordinary man now had the MATERIALS to construct one.** Read the definition of *heretical* again: heresy threatened "*the right of the Church to DECIDE on what should be believed.*" **Print did not merely spread wrong ideas; it destroyed the monopoly on deciding which ideas were wrong.** That is why the Index followed in **1558.**

Source A — Erasmus, a Latin scholar and Catholic reformer who criticised Catholic excesses but kept his distance from Luther, in *Adages* (1508): *"**To what corner of the world do they not fly, these SWARMS OF NEW BOOKS? It may be that one here and there contributes something worth knowing, BUT THE VERY MULTITUDE OF THEM IS HURTFUL TO SCHOLARSHIP, BECAUSE IT CREATES A GLUT, and even in good things SATIETY is most harmful... [printers] fill the world with books, not just trifling things... but STUPID, IGNORANT, SLANDEROUS, SCANDALOUS, RAVING, IRRELIGIOUS AND SEDITIOUS books, and the number of them is such that EVEN THE VALUABLE PUBLICATIONS LOSE THEIR VALUE.**"*

★★★★★ **Erasmus's complaint is worth taking seriously rather than mocking, because it is the oldest version of an argument being made again today.** His objection is **not** that books are bad but that **volume destroys discrimination** — when everything is published, the reader cannot tell what is worth reading, and "*even the valuable publications lose their value.*" ★ **Substitute "social media" for "printers" and the passage reads as though written last year.** For an essay on **information overload or misinformation**, this 1508 quotation is far more striking than any contemporary one. ⚠️ **And note NCERT's visual evidence of the same fear:** a sixteenth-century woodcut, *The Macabre Dance*, in which "*the coming of print is associated with THE END OF THE WORLD. The interior of the printer's workshop here is the site of A DANCE OF DEATH. SKELETAL FIGURES CONTROL THE PRINTER AND HIS WORKERS, define and dictate what is to be done.*"

Words: ★ **Satiety** — "the state of being fulfilled much beyond the point of satisfaction." ★ **Seditious** — "action, speech or writing that is seen as **OPPOSING THE GOVERNMENT.**"

4 The Reading Mania ★ ★ ★

Fact	Detail
★ ★ Literacy	"Through the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries literacy rates went up in most parts of Europe. CHURCHES OF DIFFERENT DENOMINATIONS SET UP SCHOOLS IN VILLAGES, carrying literacy to PEASANTS AND ARTISANS. ★ By the end of the eighteenth century, in some parts of Europe literacy rates were as high as 60 TO 80 PER CENT "
★ ★ The result	"As literacy and schools spread... there was A VIRTUAL READING MANIA. People wanted books to read and printers produced books in ever-increasing numbers "

The new popular forms — ★ ★ ★ :

Form	Detail
Pedlars	"Booksellers employed pedlars who roamed around villages, carrying little books for sale "
★ Almanacs	" ritual calendars " — "an annual publication giving astronomical data, information about the movements of the sun and moon, timing of full tides and eclipses, and much else of importance in the everyday life of people "
★ ★ Penny chapbooks (England)	"carried by petty pedlars known as ★ CHAPMEN, and sold for a PENNY, so that even the poor could buy them " — "pocket-size books... popular from the time of the sixteenth-century print revolution"
★ ★ Bibliothèque Bleue (France)	" low-priced small books printed on POOR QUALITY PAPER, and bound in CHEAP BLUE COVERS "
Romances and "histories"	" romances, printed on FOUR TO SIX PAGES, and the more substantial 'histories' which were stories about the past "
★ ★ The periodical press	"developed from the early eighteenth century, COMBINING INFORMATION ABOUT CURRENT AFFAIRS WITH ENTERTAINMENT. Newspapers and journals carried information about wars and trade, as well as news of developments in other places "
★ ★ Science and philosophy	" Ancient and medieval scientific texts were compiled and published, and maps and scientific diagrams widely printed. When scientists like ISAAC NEWTON began to publish their discoveries, they could influence a much wider circle of scientifically minded readers. The writings of THOMAS PAINE, VOLTAIRE and JEAN JACQUES ROUSSEAU were also widely printed and read"

Box 2 — James Lackington, a London publisher, diary, 1791 — the best evidence in the chapter that reading reached the countryside: *"**The sale of books in general has increased PRODIGIOUSLY within the last twenty years. The poorer sort of farmers and even the poor country people in general who before that period spent their winter evenings in RELATING STORIES OF WITCHES, GHOSTS, HOBGOBLINS ... now SHORTEN THE WINTER NIGHT BY HEARING THEIR SONS AND DAUGHTERS READ THEM TALES, ROMANCES, etc.** ★ If JOHN goes to town with a load of hay, he is charged to be sure not to forget to bring home *Peregrine Pickle's Adventure...* and when DOLLY is sent to sell her eggs, she is commissioned to purchase *The History of Joseph Andrews.*"* 🎯 Read that closely — it captures the transition exactly. The parents still cannot read; the children read aloud to them; and the family's entertainment shifts from ghosts and hobgoblins to printed novels. ★ This is the hearing public and the reading public intermingling, observed in a single household.

👤 4.1 "Tremble, therefore, tyrants of the world!" ★★ ★

*"By the mid-eighteenth century, there was a **common conviction that BOOKS WERE A MEANS OF SPREADING PROGRESS AND ENLIGHTENMENT. Many believed that BOOKS COULD CHANGE THE WORLD, LIBERATE SOCIETY FROM DESPOTISM AND TYRANNY, and herald a time when REASON AND INTELLECT WOULD RULE.**"*

★★★ **Louis-Sébastien Mercier**, a novelist in eighteenth-century France: *"**The printing press is THE MOST POWERFUL ENGINE OF PROGRESS and PUBLIC OPINION IS THE FORCE THAT WILL SWEEP DESPOTISM AWAY.**"* — and *"**in many of Mercier's novels, the heroes are TRANSFORMED BY ACTS OF READING. They devour books, are lost in the world books create, and become enlightened in the process.**"* Hence: ★★ *"**TREMBLE, THEREFORE, TYRANTS OF THE WORLD! TREMBLE BEFORE THE VIRTUAL WRITER!**"*

Source B — Mercier on the experience of reading: *"**Anyone who had seen me reading would have compared me to A MAN DYING OF THIRST WHO WAS GULPING DOWN SOME FRESH, PURE WATER... Lighting my lamp with extraordinary caution, I threw myself HUNGRILY into the reading... A clock struck off the hours in the silence of the shadows, AND I HEARD NOTHING. My lamp began to run out of oil... but still I read on. I could not even take out time to raise the wick FOR FEAR OF INTERRUPTING MY PLEASURE. HOW THOSE NEW IDEAS RUSHED INTO MY BRAIN! HOW MY INTELLIGENCE ADOPTED THEM!**"*

Word: ★ **Despotism** — "**a system of governance in which ABSOLUTE POWER is exercised by an individual, UNREGULATED BY LEGAL AND CONSTITUTIONAL CHECKS.**"

FR 4.2 Print culture and the French Revolution — ★★ ★★ ★ NCERT asks this directly

THREE ARGUMENTS ARE USUALLY PUT FORWARD

FIRST -- PRINT POPULARISED ENLIGHTENMENT IDEAS

"Collectively, their writings provided A **CRITICAL COMMENTARY ON TRADITION, SUPERSTITION AND DESPOTISM. They argued for THE RULE OF REASON RATHER THAN CUSTOM, and demanded that EVERYTHING BE JUDGED THROUGH THE APPLICATION OF REASON AND RATIONALITY. THEY ATTACKED THE SACRED AUTHORITY OF THE CHURCH AND THE DESPOTIC POWER OF THE STATE, thus ERODING THE LEGITIMACY OF A SOCIAL ORDER BASED ON TRADITION. Those who read VOLTAIRE and ROUSSEAU 'SAW THE WORLD THROUGH NEW EYES, EYES THAT WERE QUESTIONING, CRITICAL AND RATIONAL.'**"

SECOND -- PRINT CREATED A CULTURE OF DIALOGUE AND DEBATE

"ALL VALUES, NORMS AND INSTITUTIONS WERE RE-EVALUATED AND DISCUSSED BY A PUBLIC that had become AWARE OF THE POWER OF REASON, and recognised THE NEED TO QUESTION EXISTING IDEAS AND BELIEFS. Within this public culture, NEW IDEAS OF SOCIAL REVOLUTION CAME INTO BEING."

THIRD -- THE LITERATURE THAT MOCKED THE ROYALTY

"By the 1780s there was AN OUTPOURING OF LITERATURE THAT MOCKED THE ROYALTY AND CRITICISED THEIR MORALITY... CARTOONS AND CARICATURES typically suggested that THE MONARCHY REMAINED ABSORBED ONLY IN SENSUAL PLEASURES WHILE THE COMMON PEOPLE SUFFERED IMMENSE HARDSHIPS. This literature CIRCULATED UNDERGROUND and led to THE GROWTH OF HOSTILE SENTIMENTS AGAINST THE MONARCHY."

★★★★ And NCERT's qualification, which is the mark of a good answer — do not omit it: *

"How do we look at these arguments? **THERE CAN BE NO DOUBT THAT PRINT HELPS THE SPREAD OF IDEAS. BUT WE MUST REMEMBER THAT PEOPLE DID NOT READ JUST ONE KIND OF LITERATURE. If they read the ideas of Voltaire and Rousseau, THEY WERE ALSO EXPOSED TO MONARCHICAL AND CHURCH PROPAGANDA. THEY WERE NOT INFLUENCED DIRECTLY BY EVERYTHING THEY READ OR SAW. THEY ACCEPTED SOME IDEAS AND REJECTED OTHERS. THEY INTERPRETED THINGS THEIR OWN WAY.** ★★

PRINT DID NOT DIRECTLY SHAPE THEIR MINDS, BUT IT DID OPEN UP THE POSSIBILITY OF THINKING DIFFERENTLY."*

🌀 That last sentence is the most sophisticated formulation in the chapter and it is exactly what an examiner rewards. Print is **not** a cause that produces an effect in readers' heads; it is a **condition of possibility**. Readers are **active interpreters**, not passive receivers — which is why the same press that carried Voltaire also carried Church propaganda. ★ Use this framing for any question about media influence, then or now.

5 The Nineteenth Century — new readers

👤 5.1 Children, women and workers ★★★★★

Group	Detail
★★ Children	"As primary education became COMPULSORY from the late nineteenth century , children became an important category of readers. Production of SCHOOL TEXTBOOKS became critical for the publishing industry. ★ A CHILDREN'S PRESS, devoted to literature for children alone, was set up in FRANCE in 1857 "
★★★★ The Grimms — and what was edited out	"The Grimm Brothers in Germany spent years compiling traditional folk tales gathered from peasants. ⚠️ What they collected was EDITED before the stories were published in a collection in 1812. ANYTHING THAT WAS CONSIDERED UNSUITABLE FOR CHILDREN OR WOULD APPEAR VULGAR TO THE ELITES WAS NOT INCLUDED in the published version. RURAL FOLK TALES THUS ACQUIRED A NEW FORM. ★★ In this way, PRINT RECORDED OLD TALES BUT ALSO CHANGED THEM "
★★ Women as readers	Penny magazines "especially meant for women, as were manuals teaching PROPER BEHAVIOUR AND HOUSEKEEPING ". The Penny Magazine was published 1832–1835 by the Society for the Diffusion of Useful Knowledge , aimed primarily at the working class
★★★★ Women as writers	"Some of the best-known novelists were women: JANE AUSTEN, THE BRONTE SISTERS, GEORGE ELIOT. ★ Their writings became important in DEFINING A NEW TYPE OF WOMAN: A PERSON WITH WILL, STRENGTH OF PERSONALITY, DETERMINATION AND THE POWER TO THINK "
★★ Workers and lending libraries	" Lending libraries had been in existence from the SEVENTEENTH century. In the nineteenth century, lending libraries in England became instruments for EDUCATING WHITE-COLLAR WORKERS, ARTISANS AND LOWER-MIDDLE-CLASS PEOPLE. ★ After the working day was gradually SHORTENED from the mid-nineteenth century, workers had SOME TIME FOR SELF-IMPROVEMENT AND SELF-EXPRESSION. THEY WROTE POLITICAL TRACTS AND AUTOBIOGRAPHIES IN LARGE NUMBERS "

🔗 ★★★★★ The Grimm detail matters and connects straight to Ch.1 §3.1. There you learnt the Grimms collected folktales **to prove a German nation existed**; here you learn they **edited out whatever would seem vulgar to elites.** ★ The "**authentic voice of the people**" was **curated before publication** — which is a caution about every claim to have recovered a pure folk tradition, including the Indian folklore revival in Ch.2 §4.

Box 3 — reading against the odds: ★ Thomas Wood, a Yorkshire mechanic, *"narrated how he would **RENT OLD NEWSPAPERS** and read them **BY FIRELIGHT** in the evenings **AS HE COULD NOT AFFORD CANDLES**."* And the Russian revolutionary author **Maxim Gorky's *My Childhood* and *My University*** give "glimpses of such struggles."

⚙️ 5.2 Further innovations ★★ ★

Innovation	Detail
Late 18th century	"the press came to be made out of METAL "
★★ Mid-19th century	" RICHARD M. HOE of NEW YORK had perfected the POWER-DRIVEN CYLINDRICAL PRESS . This was capable of printing 8,000 SHEETS PER HOUR . This press was particularly useful for printing NEWSPAPERS "
★ Late 19th century	"the OFFSET PRESS was developed which could print up to SIX COLOURS at a time "
From c. 1900	" ELECTRICALLY OPERATED presses accelerated printing operations", plus better paper feeding, plates, automatic paper reels and photoelectric colour controls
★★ Selling strategies	Serialised novels in periodicals — "which gave birth to A PARTICULAR WAY OF WRITING NOVELS "; ★ the SHILLING SERIES in 1920s England; ★ the DUST COVER or book jacket — "a twentieth-century innovation"; and with the Great Depression of the 1930s , publishers "brought out CHEAP PAPERBACK EDITIONS " to sustain buying

🎯 **Note the jump: Gutenberg's 250 sheets an hour → Hoe's 8,000.** ★ **A thirty-two-fold increase is what made the DAILY NEWSPAPER possible** — and the daily newspaper is what made mass politics possible. (Hold this against Ch.2's nationalist press and §9 below.)

6 India and the World of Print

📖 6.1 Manuscripts before print ★★ ★

*"India had a very rich and old tradition of **HANDWRITTEN MANUSCRIPTS** — in **SANSKRIT, ARABIC, PERSIAN**, as well as in various **VERNACULAR languages**. Manuscripts were **copied on PALM LEAVES** or on **HANDMADE PAPER**. Pages were sometimes **beautifully illustrated**. They would be **either pressed between WOODEN COVERS or SEWN TOGETHER** to ensure preservation. ★ **Manuscripts continued to be produced TILL WELL AFTER the introduction of print, down to the late nineteenth century.**"*

Why they were not widely used — ★★ ★:

- *"Manuscripts were **HIGHLY EXPENSIVE AND FRAGILE**. They had to be **handled carefully**, and they could not be read easily **AS THE SCRIPT WAS WRITTEN IN DIFFERENT STYLES**. So **manuscripts were NOT WIDELY USED IN EVERYDAY LIFE**."*
- ★★ ★ *"Even though **pre-colonial BENGAL** had developed **AN EXTENSIVE NETWORK OF VILLAGE PRIMARY SCHOOLS**, **STUDENTS VERY OFTEN DID NOT READ TEXTS. THEY ONLY LEARNT TO WRITE**. Teachers **DICTATED PORTIONS OF TEXTS FROM MEMORY** and students **WROTE THEM DOWN**. **MANY THUS BECAME LITERATE WITHOUT EVER ACTUALLY READING ANY KINDS OF TEXTS**."*

🎯 ★ ★ ★ ★ That last fact is startling and very quotable: literacy without reading. Bengal had schools, teachers and literate students — and no books in the students' hands. Knowledge moved from the teacher's memory to the student's hand, never through a text the student could question. ★ Print's real gift was not literacy but ACCESS TO A TEXT THAT COULD BE RE-READ, COMPARED AND DISPUTED — which is precisely what §7's reform debates required.

🖨️ 6.2 Print comes to India ★ ★ ★

Date	Event
★ ★ Mid-16th century	"The printing press first came to GOA with PORTUGUESE MISSIONARIES. Jesuit priests learnt KONKANI and printed several tracts "
★ By 1674	"about 50 books had been printed in the Konkani and Kanara languages "
★ ★ 1579	"Catholic priests printed the first TAMIL book at COCHIN "
★ ★ 1713	"the first MALAYALAM book was printed by them"
★ By 1710	" Dutch Protestant missionaries had printed 32 TAMIL TEXTS , many of them translations of older works"
English press	" did NOT grow in India till quite late even though the English East India Company began to import presses from the late seventeenth century "

★ ★ ★ ★ The Hickey episode — a very good short-answer story:

FROM 1780 -- "JAMES AUGUSTUS HICKEY began to edit the BENGAL GAZETTE, a WEEKLY MAGAZINE that described itself as 'A COMMERCIAL PAPER OPEN TO ALL, BUT INFLUENCED BY NONE'. So it was PRIVATE ENGLISH ENTERPRISE, PROUD OF ITS INDEPENDENCE FROM COLONIAL INFLUENCE, that began English printing in India."

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WHAT HE PRINTED

- "a lot of ADVERTISEMENTS, including those that related to THE IMPORT AND SALE OF SLAVES"
- "But he also published A LOT OF GOSSIP ABOUT THE COMPANY'S SENIOR OFFICIALS IN INDIA."

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"Enraged by this, Governor-General WARREN HASTINGS PERSECUTED HICKEY, and ENCOURAGED THE PUBLICATION OF OFFICIALLY SANCTIONED NEWSPAPERS THAT COULD COUNTER THE FLOW OF INFORMATION THAT DAMAGED THE IMAGE OF THE COLONIAL GOVERNMENT."

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AND THE INDIAN BEGINNING

"There were INDIANS, TOO, who began to publish Indian newspapers. THE FIRST TO APPEAR WAS THE WEEKLY BENGAL GAZETTE, brought out by GANGADHAR BHATTACHARYA, WHO WAS CLOSE TO RAMMOHUN ROY."

🎯 ★ ★ ★ Note the shape of the first censorship in India: it was aimed at an ENGLISHMAN, and answered with STATE-SPONSORED NEWSPAPERS rather than a ban. Hastings's response — funding loyal papers to "counter the flow of information" — is the birth of government propaganda in India, and it precedes the first press regulation by decades.

7 Religious Reform and Public Debates ★★☆☆

★★★ The framing sentence — quote it: *"These debates were **carried out IN PUBLIC AND IN PRINT. PRINTED TRACTS AND NEWSPAPERS NOT ONLY SPREAD THE NEW IDEAS, BUT THEY SHAPED THE NATURE OF THE DEBATE. A WIDER PUBLIC COULD NOW PARTICIPATE in these public discussions and EXPRESS THEIR VIEWS. NEW IDEAS EMERGED THROUGH THESE CLASHES OF OPINIONS.**"*

ॐ The Hindu reform debate

*"This was a time of **intense controversies between social and religious reformers and the HINDU ORTHODOXY** over matters like ★ **WIDOW IMMOLATION, MONOTHEISM, BRAHMANICAL PRIESTHOOD and IDOLATRY.** In Bengal, as the debate developed, **tracts and newspapers proliferated...** ★★ **To reach a wider audience, THE IDEAS WERE PRINTED IN THE EVERYDAY, SPOKEN LANGUAGE OF ORDINARY PEOPLE.**"*

Publication	Detail
★★★ Sambad Kaumudi	" <i>Rammohun Roy published it from 1821</i> "
★★★ Samachar Chandrika	" <i>the HINDU ORTHODOXY COMMISSIONED it to oppose his opinions</i> "
★★ Jam-i-Jahan Nama and Shamsul Akhbar	" <i>From 1822, two PERSIAN newspapers were published</i> "
★★ Bombay Samachar	" <i>In the same year, a GUJARATI newspaper made its appearance</i> "

🎯 ★★★ The most instructive detail is that the orthodoxy COMMISSIONED ITS OWN NEWSPAPER. Conservatives did not merely denounce print — **they adopted it to fight back.** ★ A new medium does not favour one side; it changes the terms on which BOTH sides must argue. Once Rammohun Roy argued in Bengali prose for a general readership, his opponents had to do the same, and **the debate moved out of the pandit's circle into a public that could judge.**

🕌 The Muslim response ★★☆☆

THE ANXIETY

"In north India, the ULAMA were deeply anxious about THE COLLAPSE OF MUSLIM DYNASTIES. THEY FEARED THAT COLONIAL RULERS WOULD ENCOURAGE CONVERSION, CHANGE THE MUSLIM PERSONAL LAWS."

THE RESPONSE -- print, adopted at once

- "they used CHEAP LITHOGRAPHIC PRESSES"
- "published PERSIAN AND URDU TRANSLATIONS OF HOLY SCRIPTURES"
- "printed RELIGIOUS NEWSPAPERS AND TRACTS"

THE DEOBAND SEMINARY, FOUNDED 1867

"published THOUSANDS UPON THOUSANDS OF FATWAS telling Muslim readers HOW TO CONDUCT THEMSELVES IN THEIR EVERYDAY LIVES, and EXPLAINING THE MEANINGS OF ISLAMIC DOCTRINES."

"All through the nineteenth century, A NUMBER OF MUSLIM SECTS AND SEMINARIES APPEARED, EACH WITH A DIFFERENT INTERPRETATION OF FAITH, each keen on ENLARGING ITS FOLLOWING and COUNTERING THE INFLUENCE OF ITS OPPONENTS."

URDU PRINT HELPED THEM CONDUCT THESE BATTLES IN PUBLIC."

Words: ★ Ulama — legal scholars of Islam and the sharia (a body of Islamic law). ★ Fatwa — "a legal pronouncement on Islamic law usually given by a MUFTI (legal scholar) to clarify issues on which the law is uncertain."

📖 Hindu religious texts in print

- ★★ "The first printed edition of the RAMCHARITMANAS of TULSIDAS, a sixteenth-century text, came out from CALCUTTA in 1810. By the mid-nineteenth century, cheap LITHOGRAPHIC editions flooded north Indian markets."*
- ★★ "From the 1880s, the NAVAL KISHORE PRESS at LUCKNOW and the SHRI VENKATESHWAR PRESS in BOMBAY published numerous religious texts in vernaculars."*
- ★★★ "In their printed and PORTABLE form, these could be read easily by the faithful AT ANY PLACE AND TIME. THEY COULD ALSO BE READ OUT TO LARGE GROUPS OF ILLITERATE MEN AND WOMEN."*

★★★★ And the two-sided conclusion — give both halves: "Religious texts, therefore, reached A VERY WIDE CIRCLE of people, encouraging DISCUSSIONS, DEBATES AND CONTROVERSIES WITHIN AND AMONG DIFFERENT RELIGIONS. ... Print did not only stimulate THE PUBLICATION OF CONFLICTING OPINIONS amongst communities, BUT IT ALSO CONNECTED COMMUNITIES AND PEOPLE in different parts of India. NEWSPAPERS CONVEYED NEWS FROM ONE PLACE TO ANOTHER, ★★ CREATING PAN-INDIAN IDENTITIES."* 🎯 Print did both things at once — it sharpened religious controversy AND it built a nation. ★ The same technology that let each sect fight its rivals in public also let a reader in Madras know what had happened in Punjab last week. (This is the infrastructure behind Ch.2's "pan-Indian identities" and Ch.1's account of how nations are imagined.)

Source D — why newspapers? (Bombay Telegraph and Courier, 6 January 1849): a Marathi newspaper proposed "with a view of **affording useful information on every topic of local interest**. It will be **OPEN FOR FREE DISCUSSION** on subjects of general utility, scientific investigation... **the patronage and support of all interested in THE DIFFUSION OF KNOWLEDGE AND WELFARE OF THE PEOPLE is earnestly solicited.**"* ★★ (Native Opinion, 3 April 1870): "The task of the native newspapers and political associations **IS IDENTICAL TO THE ROLE OF THE OPPOSITION IN THE HOUSE OF COMMONS in Parliament in England**. That is of **critically examining government policy to suggest improvements**... These associations ought to **carefully study the particular issues, gather diverse relevant information**... and this will surely **earn it considerable influence.**"* 🎯 ★★★ That 1870 statement is remarkable and worth quoting in a Polity answer. In a country with **no elected legislature and no opposition**, Indians defined the press as **performing the Opposition's constitutional function**. ★ Where representative institutions are absent, the newspaper becomes the substitute legislature — which explains both why the nationalist press mattered so much and why the colonial state feared it.

8 New Forms of Publication

"Printing created an appetite for NEW KINDS OF WRITING. As more and more people could now read, THEY WANTED TO SEE THEIR OWN LIVES, EXPERIENCES, EMOTIONS AND RELATIONSHIPS REFLECTED IN WHAT THEY READ. ★ THE NOVEL, a literary form which had developed in Europe, IDEALLY CATERED TO THIS NEED. It soon acquired DISTINCTIVELY INDIAN FORMS AND STYLES." Alongside came lyrics, short stories, and essays about social and political matters.

★★★ The new visual culture:

- "With the setting up of an increasing number of printing presses, **visual images could be easily reproduced in multiple copies**. Painters like ★★ **RAJA RAVI VARMA** produced images for **MASS CIRCULATION**. ★ **Poor WOOD ENGRAVERS** who made woodblocks **SET UP SHOP NEAR THE LETTERPRESSES**, and were employed by print shops."
- ★★ *"Cheap prints and calendars, easily available in the bazaar, could be bought **EVEN BY THE POOR** to decorate the walls of their homes or places of work. These prints began **shaping popular ideas about MODERNITY AND TRADITION, RELIGION AND POLITICS, and SOCIETY AND CULTURE**."*
- ★★ *"By the 1870s, **CARICATURES AND CARTOONS** were being published in journals and newspapers, commenting on social and political issues. Some **ridiculed the educated Indians' fascination with Western tastes and clothes**, while others **expressed the fear of social change**. ★ There were **IMPERIAL caricatures LAMPOONING NATIONALISTS**, as well as **NATIONALIST cartoons CRITICISING IMPERIAL RULE**."*

🧐 8.1 Women and print — ★★★★★ NCERT asks "what did print mean to women?"

THE OPENING

"Lives and feelings of women began to be written in PARTICULARLY VIVID AND INTENSE WAYS. WOMEN'S READING, THEREFORE, INCREASED ENORMOUSLY IN MIDDLE-CLASS HOMES."

"LIBERAL HUSBANDS AND FATHERS began EDUCATING THEIR WOMENFOLK AT HOME, and SENT THEM TO SCHOOLS when women's schools were set up in the cities and towns AFTER THE MID-NINETEENTH CENTURY."

"Many journals began CARRYING WRITINGS BY WOMEN, and EXPLAINED WHY WOMEN SHOULD BE EDUCATED. They also carried A SYLLABUS and attached SUITABLE READING MATTER for HOME-BASED SCHOOLING."

THE RESISTANCE

"BUT NOT ALL FAMILIES WERE LIBERAL. CONSERVATIVE HINDUS BELIEVED THAT A LITERATE GIRL WOULD BE WIDOWED and MUSLIMS FEARED THAT EDUCATED WOMEN WOULD BE CORRUPTED BY READING URDU ROMANCES."

AND THE DEFIANCE

"Sometimes, REBEL WOMEN DEFIED SUCH PROHIBITION."

- a girl in a CONSERVATIVE MUSLIM FAMILY of north India "SECRETLY LEARNT TO READ AND WRITE IN URDU. Her family wanted her to read ONLY THE ARABIC QURAN WHICH SHE DID NOT UNDERSTAND. SO SHE INSISTED ON LEARNING TO READ A LANGUAGE THAT WAS HER OWN."
- RASHSUNDARI DEBI, East Bengal, "a young married girl in A VERY ORTHODOX HOUSEHOLD. LEARNT TO READ IN THE SECRECY OF HER KITCHEN. Later, she wrote her autobiography AMAR JIBAN which was published in 1876. IT WAS THE FIRST FULL-LENGTH AUTOBIOGRAPHY PUBLISHED IN THE BENGALI LANGUAGE."

🎯 ★ ★ ★ ★ ★ **Rashsundari Debi deserves to be remembered by name.** A married woman in an orthodox household **taught herself to read in her own kitchen, in secret** — and the result was **the first full-length autobiography in Bengali.** ★ **The first person to write a life story in that language was a woman who was not supposed to read.** Use this in any answer on women's education, agency, or the social impact of print. ★ **And note the Muslim girl's reason:** she was permitted the **Arabic Quran** she could not understand and forbidden **Urdu, which she could.** **The prohibition was not on reading but on COMPREHENSION** — which tells you exactly what was feared.

★ ★ ★ Women writing about women's lives:

Writer	Detail
★ ★ Kailashbashini Debi (from the 1860s)	"a few Bengali women... wrote books highlighting the experiences of women — about how women were IMPRISONED AT HOME, KEPT IN IGNORANCE, FORCED TO DO HARD DOMESTIC LABOUR and TREATED UNJUSTLY BY THE VERY PEOPLE THEY SERVED "
★ ★ ★ Tarabai Shinde and Pandita Ramabai (1880s, present-day Maharashtra)	"wrote with PASSIONATE ANGER about the MISERABLE LIVES OF UPPER-CASTE HINDU WOMEN, ESPECIALLY WIDOWS "
★ ★ A woman in a Tamil novel	"For various reasons, MY WORLD IS SMALL... MORE THAN HALF MY LIFE'S HAPPINESS HAS COME FROM BOOKS "

Source E — Begum Rokeya Sakhawat Hossein, noted educationist, addressing the **Bengal Women's Education Conference, 1926**, condemning men "for withholding education from women in the name of religion": "The opponents of female education say that **women will become unruly... Fie! They call themselves Muslims and yet GO AGAINST THE BASIC TENET OF ISLAM WHICH GIVES WOMEN AN EQUAL RIGHT TO EDUCATION.** ★ **IF MEN ARE NOT LED ASTRAY ONCE EDUCATED, WHY SHOULD WOMEN?**" 🎯 **Note her strategy — it is exactly Ishwarchandra Vidyasagar's and Olympe de Gouges's.** She does not argue against religion; she argues that **the opponents have misread their own faith**, and then poses a question of **simple consistency.** ★ **Turning the opponent's own principle against their practice is the most effective reformist move available**, and you have now met it in four chapters.

★ ★ ★ Hindi, Punjab and Battala:

- "While Urdu, Tamil, Bengali and Marathi print culture had developed early, **HINDI PRINTING BEGAN SERIOUSLY ONLY FROM THE 1870s.** Soon, a large segment of it was devoted to **THE EDUCATION OF WOMEN.**"
- "In the early twentieth century, **journals, written for and sometimes EDITED BY women, became extremely popular.** They discussed **women's education, widowhood, widow remarriage and the national movement**", plus household and fashion lessons, short stories and serialised novels.
- ⚠️ ★ ★ ★ **The conservative counter-literature:** "In **PUNJAB... RAM CHADDHA published the fast-selling ISTRI DHARM VICHAR TO TEACH WOMEN HOW TO BE OBEDIENT WIVES.** The **KHALSA TRACT SOCIETY published cheap booklets with a similar message, many in the form of dialogues about the qualities of a good woman.**"
- ★ ★ **Battala:** "In Bengal, an entire area in central Calcutta — **the BATTALA** — was devoted to the printing of popular books. Here you could buy **cheap editions of religious tracts and scriptures, as well as literature that was considered OBSCENE AND SCANDALOUS... PEDLARS TOOK THE BATTALA PUBLICATIONS TO HOMES, ENABLING WOMEN TO READ THEM IN THEIR LEISURE TIME.**"

⚠️ ★★★★★ **Print did not automatically liberate women — it armed both sides.** The same presses produced **Rashsundari Debi's autobiography** and **Istri Dharm Vichar**, a manual on wifely obedience; journals edited by women and **Khalsa Tract Society** booklets on "the qualities of a good woman." ★ A technology of free expression multiplies whatever arguments a society already contains. Say this and you avoid the naive version of the answer.

The visual anxiety NCERT prints: woodcuts such as ★ **Ghor Kali (The End of the World)** show "*the husband totally dominated by his wife who is perched on his shoulder*", being cruel to his mother, dragging her by a noose; another shows the man playing the veena while the woman smokes a hookah — "*the artist's fear that the cultural impact of the West has TURNED THE FAMILY UPSIDE DOWN*", because ★ *"**the move towards women's education in the late nineteenth century CREATED ANXIETY ABOUT THE BREAKDOWN OF TRADITIONAL FAMILY ROLES.**"*

🔥 8.2 Print and the poor — ★★★★★ NCERT asks this directly

Development	Detail
★ Cheap books	" <i>Very cheap small books were brought to markets in nineteenth-century MADRAS towns and SOLD AT CROSSROADS, allowing poor people travelling to markets to buy them</i> "
★★ Public libraries	" <i>set up from the early twentieth century, EXPANDING THE ACCESS TO BOOKS. These libraries were located mostly in cities and towns, and at times in prosperous villages. ★ For RICH LOCAL PATRONS, setting up a library was A WAY OF ACQUIRING PRESTIGE</i> "
★★★ Caste protest in print	" <i>From the late nineteenth century, issues of CASTE DISCRIMINATION began to be written about in many printed tracts and essays. ★★ JYOTIBA PHULE, the Maratha pioneer of 'low caste' protest movements, wrote about the injustices of the caste system in his GULAMGIRI (1871). In the twentieth century, ★★ B.R. AMBEDKAR in Maharashtra and E.V. RAMASWAMY NAICKER in Madras, better known as PERIYAR, wrote powerfully on caste and THEIR WRITINGS WERE READ BY PEOPLE ALL OVER INDIA. Local protest movements and sects also created popular journals and tracts criticising ancient scriptures and ENVISIONING A NEW AND JUST FUTURE</i> "
★★★ Workers' own writing	" <i>Workers in factories were too overworked and lacked the education to write much. BUT KASHIBABA, a KANPUR MILLWORKER, wrote and published CHHOTE AUR BADE KA SAWAL in 1938 to show THE LINKS BETWEEN CASTE AND CLASS EXPLOITATION. The poems of another Kanpur millworker, writing as ★ SUDARSHAN CHAKR between 1935 and 1955, were collected as SACCHI KAVITAYAN</i> "
★★ Workers' libraries	" <i>By the 1930s, BANGALORE COTTON MILLWORKERS SET UP LIBRARIES TO EDUCATE THEMSELVES, following the example of BOMBAY workers. These were sponsored by SOCIAL REFORMERS who tried to RESTRICT EXCESSIVE DRINKING among them, to bring LITERACY and, sometimes, to PROPAGATE THE MESSAGE OF NATIONALISM</i> "

🎯 ★★★★★ Kashibaba's title tells you why print mattered to the poor: **Chhote aur Bade ka Sawal** — "the question of the small and the great." A Kanpur millworker published a book arguing that caste and class exploitation are linked — an argument that could not have travelled beyond his own mill in an oral culture. ★ Print gave the subordinated the one thing oral culture cannot: the ability to address strangers, at a distance, without permission. That is why Phule, Ambedkar and Periyar could be "*read by people all over India.*" ⚠️ But note the qualifier in the last row: workers' libraries were sponsored by reformers who also wanted to curb their drinking. ★ Access to print came bundled with someone else's improving agenda — a pattern worth flagging rather than romanticising.

BEFORE 1798 -- and the surprise
 "the colonial state under the East India Company was NOT TOO CONCERNED WITH CENSORSHIP. STRANGELY, ITS EARLY MEASURES TO CONTROL PRINTED MATTER WERE DIRECTED AGAINST ENGLISHMEN IN INDIA who were CRITICAL OF COMPANY MISRULE and hated the actions of particular Company officers.

THE COMPANY WAS WORRIED THAT SUCH CRITICISMS MIGHT BE USED BY ITS CRITICS IN ENGLAND TO ATTACK ITS TRADE MONOPOLY."

BY THE 1820s -- "the CALCUTTA SUPREME COURT passed certain regulations to CONTROL PRESS FREEDOM and the Company began ENCOURAGING PUBLICATION OF NEWSPAPERS THAT WOULD CELEBRATE BRITISH RULE."

1835 -- "faced with URGENT PETITIONS BY EDITORS of English and vernacular newspapers, Governor-General BENTINCK agreed to REVISE PRESS LAWS. THOMAS MACAULAY, a liberal colonial official, FORMULATED NEW RULES THAT RESTORED THE EARLIER FREEDOMS."

AFTER THE REVOLT OF 1857 -- THE TURN
 "the attitude to freedom of the press CHANGED. ENRAGED ENGLISHMEN DEMANDED A CLAMP DOWN ON THE 'NATIVE' PRESS. As VERNACULAR NEWSPAPERS BECAME ASSERTIVELY NATIONALIST, the colonial government began debating measures of STRINGENT CONTROL."

1878 -- THE VERNACULAR PRESS ACT
 "passed, MODELLED ON THE IRISH PRESS LAWS. It provided the government with EXTENSIVE RIGHTS TO CENSOR REPORTS AND EDITORIALS IN THE VERNACULAR PRESS. From now on the government KEPT REGULAR TRACK of the vernacular newspapers published in different provinces.

WHEN A REPORT WAS JUDGED AS SEDITIOUS, THE NEWSPAPER WAS WARNED, AND IF THE WARNING WAS IGNORED, THE PRESS WAS LIABLE TO BE SEIZED AND THE PRINTING MACHINERY CONFISCATED."

🌀 ★★★★★ **Two things to notice about the Vernacular Press Act.** First, it applied to the **vernacular** press only — **English-language papers were exempt**, so the law was explicitly about **who was reading**, not what was said. Second, the penalty was **confiscation of the machinery**: not a fine, not a prosecution, but **destroying the capacity to print at all**. ★ **A press that can be seized does not need to be argued with.**

★★★★★ **And the cycle that followed:**

*"**DESPITE REPRESSIVE MEASURES, NATIONALIST NEWSPAPERS GREW IN NUMBERS in all parts of India. They reported on colonial misrule and encouraged nationalist activities.** ★ **ATTEMPTS TO THROTTLE NATIONALIST CRITICISM PROVOKED MILITANT PROTEST. THIS IN TURN LED TO A RENEWED CYCLE OF PERSECUTION AND PROTESTS.** When Punjab revolutionaries were deported in 1907, **BALGANGADHAR TILAK** wrote with great sympathy about them in his ★ **KESARI**. This led to **HIS IMPRISONMENT IN 1908, provoking in turn WIDESPREAD PROTESTS ALL OVER INDIA.**"*

Box 5 — the later machinery of control: ★ *"During the **First World War**, under the **DEFENCE OF INDIA RULES**, **22 NEWSPAPERS HAD TO FURNISH SECURITIES. OF THESE, 18 SHUT DOWN RATHER THAN COMPLY.**"* The **Sedition Committee Report under ROWLATT in 1919** further strengthened controls. At the outbreak of the Second World War the **DEFENCE OF INDIA ACT** allowed censoring of war-related reports — *"**All reports about the QUIT INDIA movement came under its purview.** ★ ★ **IN AUGUST 1942, ABOUT 90 NEWSPAPERS WERE SUPPRESSED.**"*
Box 4 — and the difficulty of buying loyalty: *"the government found it **hard to find candidates for editorship of LOYALIST papers.** When **Sanders**, editor of the *Statesman* (founded 1877), was approached, he **asked rudely HOW MUCH HE WOULD BE PAID FOR SUFFERING THE LOSS OF FREEDOM.** The *Friend of India* **refused a government subsidy, fearing that this would force it to be OBEDIENT TO GOVERNMENT COMMANDS.**"*

Source F — Gandhi, 1922 — ★ ★ ★ ★ the single most quotable line in the chapter: *"**LIBERTY OF SPEECH... LIBERTY OF THE PRESS... FREEDOM OF ASSOCIATION. The Government of India is now seeking to CRUSH THE THREE POWERFUL VEHICLES OF EXPRESSING AND CULTIVATING PUBLIC OPINION. THE FIGHT FOR SWARAJ, FOR KHILAFAT... MEANS A FIGHT FOR THIS THREATENED FREEDOM BEFORE ALL ELSE.**"*

🎯 ★ ★ ★ ★ Gandhi is making a claim about **PRIORITY**, and it is worth unpacking in a **Polity or Essay answer**. He does not say these freedoms are among the aims of swaraj; he says the fight for swaraj **IS** the fight for them, "*before all else.*" ★ **Because without speech, press and association there is no way to build the movement that could win anything else** — these three are not among the goods a free country enjoys but **the preconditions of becoming one.** 🔗 **This is the direct ancestry of Article 19(1)(a) and (c) of our Constitution**, and the reason the framers were so careful about press freedom: **they had all been prosecuted under these laws.**

● Prelims traps

Trap	The truth
"Print began in Europe"	★★ China, Japan and Korea — hand printing from AD 594 in China; paper was also invented there
"The Diamond Sutra was printed in Japan"	★★ "the oldest CHINESE book, printed in AD 868 " — Buddhist missionaries took hand printing to Japan around AD 768–770
"Chinese print was mainly commercial from the start"	★★ The imperial state was long the major producer, printing civil service examination textbooks ; diversification to merchants, leisure and women's writing came in the seventeenth century
"Marco Polo returned in 1275"	★ 1295 , bringing woodblock printing knowledge to Italy
"Gutenberg invented the press in Italy in the 1450s"	★★ Strasbourg, Germany, in the 1430s; perfected by 1448 ; the first book was the Bible, about 180 copies in three years
"Gutenberg's press printed 8,000 sheets an hour"	★★ 250 sheets per hour. 8,000 was Richard M. Hoe's power-driven cylindrical press , mid-nineteenth century
"Printed books immediately looked different from manuscripts"	★★★ They closely resembled them — metal letters imitating ornamental handwriting, hand-illuminated borders, space left blank for the buyer's chosen decoration ; elites preferred the lack of uniformity
"20 million books were printed in the sixteenth century"	★★ 20 million in the second half of the FIFTEENTH century; about 200 million in the sixteenth
"Luther opposed print"	★★★ "Printing is the ultimate gift of God and the greatest one." Ninety Five Theses, 1517 ; his New Testament sold 5,000 copies in a few weeks
"The Index of Prohibited Books began in 1517"	★★ From 1558 , after cases like Menocchio , an Italian millar who was executed
"Erasmus welcomed the flood of books"	★★★ He feared it — "the very multitude of them is hurtful to scholarship, because it creates a glut " (<i>Adages</i> , 1508)
"Chapbooks were French"	★★ Penny chapbooks were English , sold by chapmen ; the French equivalent was the Bibliothèque Bleue , on poor paper in cheap blue covers
"European literacy was under 20% by 1800"	★ "in some parts of Europe literacy rates were as high as 60 to 80 per cent " by the end of the eighteenth century
"A children's press was set up in England in 1857"	★ France, 1857 ; the Grimms' collection was 1812 , and edited to remove what was unsuitable or vulgar
"Print directly caused the French Revolution"	★★★★ NCERT's qualification: people read many kinds of literature , including monarchical and Church propaganda ; " print did not directly shape their minds, but it did open up the possibility of thinking differently "
"The first printing press in India came with the British"	★★★ Portuguese missionaries at GOA, mid-sixteenth century ; first Tamil book 1579 at Cochin ; first Malayalam book 1713
"Hickey edited an officially sponsored newspaper"	★★ The opposite — " a commercial paper open to all, but influenced by none ", printing gossip about senior Company officials ; Warren Hastings persecuted him and sponsored loyal papers
"The first Indian-run paper was Rammohun Roy's"	★★ "The first to appear was the weekly Bengal Gazette , brought out by GANGADHAR BHATTACHARYA , who was close to Rammohun Roy ." Roy published the Sambad Kaumudi from 1821
"Samachar Chandrika supported Rammohun Roy"	★★ It was commissioned by the Hindu orthodoxy to OPPOSE him

Trap	The truth
"The Deoband Seminary was founded in 1857"	★ ★ 1867, publishing thousands of fatwas
"Amar Jiban was written by Pandita Ramabai"	★ ★ ★ Rashsundari Debi, published 1876 — the first full-length autobiography in Bengali . Tarabai Shinde and Pandita Ramabai wrote in the 1880s on upper-caste widows
"Gulamgiri was written by Ambedkar"	★ ★ Jyotiba Phule, 1871. Kashibaba, a Kanpur millworker, wrote Chhote Aur Bade Ka Sawal in 1938
"The Vernacular Press Act was passed in 1857"	★ ★ ★ 1878, modelled on the Irish Press Laws, applying to the vernacular press, with seizure of press and confiscation of machinery
"Macaulay tightened the press laws"	★ ★ Under Bentinck in 1835, Macaulay formulated rules that RESTORED earlier freedoms
"Tilak was imprisoned in 1907"	★ He wrote in Kesari about the Punjab revolutionaries deported in 1907 ; he was imprisoned in 1908
"About 90 newspapers were suppressed during the Rowlatt agitation"	★ ★ August 1942, during Quit India. In the First World War , 22 papers had to furnish securities and 18 shut down

● Mains angles

- ★ ★ ★ ★ "What did the spread of print culture in nineteenth-century India mean to (a) women (b) the poor (c) reformers?" (NCERT's own — the highest-yield question here.) **Women:** middle-class reading, journals with syllabi, women novelists and autobiographers, **Rashsundari Debi's Amar Jiban (1876)**, Tarabai Shinde and Pandita Ramabai, Begum Rokeya — **but** conservative fears, *Istri Dharm Vichar*, and *Ghor Kali* woodcuts. **The poor:** cheap books at Madras crossroads, public libraries, **Phule's Gulamgiri (1871)**, Ambedkar and Periyar read across India, **Kashibaba (1938)** and **Sudarshan Chakr**, and workers' libraries in Bombay and Bangalore. **Reformers:** *Sambad Kaumudi* vs *Samachar Chandrika*, Persian and Gujarati papers, the ulama's lithographs and Deoband's fatwas, vernacular scripture editions — and "newspapers conveyed news from one place to another, creating pan-Indian identities."
- ★ ★ ★ ★ "Why did some people fear the effect of easily available printed books? Choose one example from Europe and one from India." (NCERT's own.) **Europe:** rebellious and irreligious thought, **Menocchio executed**, the **Index from 1558**, **Erasmus's glut**, the *Macabre Dance* woodcut. **India:** conservative Hindus fearing a literate girl would be widowed, Muslims fearing corruption by Urdu romances, the *Ghor Kali* image of the family turned upside down — **and the colonial state's own fear, culminating in the Vernacular Press Act.**
- ★ ★ ★ ★ "Why did some people in eighteenth-century Europe think print culture would bring enlightenment and end despotism?" — Mercier's "most powerful engine of progress" and "tremble, therefore, tyrants of the world"; heroes transformed by reading; **the three arguments about the French Revolution** — ★ and NCERT's qualification that print "did not directly shape their minds, but did open up the possibility of thinking differently."
- ★ ★ ★ ★ "Explain how print culture assisted the growth of nationalism in India." (NCERT's own.) — Vernacular papers reporting colonial misrule; **pan-Indian identities** formed by news travelling; caricatures and nationalist cartoons; **Tilak's Kesari** and the persecution–protest cycle; the **1870 claim that native newspapers perform the Opposition's role**; and **Gandhi's 1922 statement** that swaraj is the fight for speech, press and association.
- ★ ★ ★ "Write short notes on the Gutenberg Press / Erasmus's idea of the printed book / the Vernacular Press Act." (NCERT's own three.)
- ★ ★ ★ ★ "Print changed the relationship between people and authority." — Menocchio and the Index; Luther and the Reformation; the orthodoxy commissioning its own paper; Deoband's fatwas; the

Vernacular Press Act and the confiscation of machinery. ★ **The through-line: whoever could once decide what may be believed lost that monopoly.**

- ★★★★★ **Polity/Essay: freedom of the press.** — The 1798–1942 arc; **the VPA exempted English papers**, so the target was **the readership; 18 of 22 papers shutting rather than furnishing securities; 90 papers suppressed in August 1942**; editors refusing subsidies to stay free; and **Gandhi's priority claim** as the ancestry of **Article 19**.
- ★★★★★ **Essay: information abundance.** — **Erasmus in 1508** on the glut that makes even valuable publications lose their value; the **Macabre Dance**; against **Mercier** and **Luther**. ★ **A five-hundred-year-old debate that reads as though it were about the internet.**

🔗 **Cross-links to build now**

- ★★★★★ **Class 9 Ch.1 — censorship abolished in 1789**; "*opposing views of events could now be printed*"; reading aloud for the illiterate.
 - ★★★★★ **Ch.1 of this book — press freedom as THE liberal demand**; *The Club of Thinkers*; the **Grimms** and folklore as nation-building.
 - ★★★★★ **Ch.2 of this book — nationalist newspapers, Tilak**, cartoons, and the **manufacture of pan-Indian identity**.
 - ★★★★★ **Ch.4 of this book — calendars and labels** reaching the illiterate; **Ravi Varma's press**; cheap prints in poor homes.
 - ★★★★★ **Class 8 Ch.7 — the reform debates on sati, widow remarriage and women's education** that this chapter shows being **conducted in print**.
-

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Calligraphy	The art of beautiful and stylised writing
Vellum	Parchment made from animal skin
Platen	The board pressed onto the back of the paper to take the impression
Compositor	The person who composes the text for printing
Galley	The metal frame in which types are laid and text composed
Ballad	A historical account or folk tale in verse, sung or recited
Taverns	Places where people drank, ate, met friends and exchanged news
Protestant Reformation	The sixteenth-century movement to reform the Roman-dominated Catholic Church
Inquisition	A former Roman Catholic court for identifying and punishing heretics
Heretical	Beliefs not following the Church's accepted teachings — a threat to the Church's right to decide what should be believed
Satiety	Being fulfilled much beyond the point of satisfaction
Seditious	Action, speech or writing seen as opposing the government
Almanac	An annual publication of astronomical data, tides, eclipses and everyday information
Chapbook	Pocket-size books sold by travelling pedlars (chapmen)
Bibliothèque Bleue	French low-priced books on poor paper in cheap blue covers
Despotism	Absolute power exercised by an individual, unregulated by legal and constitutional checks
Denominations	Sub-groups within a religion
Ulama	Legal scholars of Islam and the sharia
Fatwa	A legal pronouncement on Islamic law , usually by a mufti
Ukiyo	<i>"Pictures of the floating world"</i> — Japanese prints of ordinary urban life
Vernacular Press Act, 1878	Modelled on the Irish Press Laws ; allowed censorship, seizure and confiscation of vernacular presses

60-Second Recap

1. ★★ **Print began in China, Japan and Korea** — hand printing from **AD 594** by rubbing paper against inked woodblocks; the **accordion book**; and the **imperial state** as the great printer, producing **civil service examination textbooks**. By the **seventeenth century** print served **merchants, leisure reading and women writers**.
2. ★★ **Japan** received hand printing from **Buddhist missionaries around AD 768–770**; the **Diamond Sutra (AD 868)** is the oldest Chinese book; Edo's **ukiyo prints** later **influenced Manet, Monet and Van Gogh** — and the original drawing was **destroyed** in making the block.
3. ★★ **To Europe: Chinese paper in the eleventh century** via the silk route; **Marco Polo brought woodblock printing in 1295**. Luxury books stayed **handwritten on vellum** for elites who **scoffed at print as "cheap vulgarities"**, while **merchants and students bought printed copies**. **More than 50 scribes** worked for one bookseller, and still supply could not meet demand.
4. ★★★ **Gutenberg, at Strasbourg in the 1430s**, adapted the **olive press** and **lead moulds** from goldsmithing; **perfected by 1448**; the **Bible, about 180 copies in three years**; **moveable type**

remained the basic technology **for 300 years; 250 sheets an hour**. ⚠️ Early printed books **imitated manuscripts**, with **blank space for the buyer's chosen decoration** — because **elites preferred that no two copies be alike**.

5. ★★ **20 million** books in the **second half of the fifteenth century**; **about 200 million** in the sixteenth — **the print revolution**, which *"transformed the lives of people, changing their relationship to information and knowledge, and with institutions and authorities."*
6. ★★★ **From a hearing public to a reading public** — but literacy was low, so printers published **ballads and folk tales, profusely illustrated**, to be **sung and recited in villages and taverns**. ★ *"Oral culture thus entered print and printed material was orally transmitted... the hearing public and reading public became intermingled."*
7. ★★★ **Print enabled dissent — and provoked fear. Luther's Ninety Five Theses (1517)** were reproduced in vast numbers, splitting the Church and beginning the **Protestant Reformation**; his **New Testament sold 5,000 copies in weeks**; *"printing is the ultimate gift of God."* Against this, **Menocchio, an Italian miller, was executed** for his own reading of the Bible, and the Church kept an ★ **Index of Prohibited Books from 1558**. **Erasmus (1508)** feared the *"swarms of new books"* would create a **glut** in which *"even the valuable publications lose their value."*
8. ★★ **The reading mania**: church schools spread literacy to **60–80% in parts of Europe**; **pedlars, almanacs, penny chapbooks (chapmen), the Bibliothèque Bleue, romances and "histories"**; the **periodical press from the early eighteenth century**; and **Newton, Paine, Voltaire and Rousseau** reaching wide audiences. **Lackington (1791)** records country people who once told ghost stories now **hearing their children read novels aloud**.
9. ★★★ **Print and the French Revolution — three arguments**: it **popularised Enlightenment ideas** attacking the sacred authority of the Church and the despotic power of the state; it **created a culture of dialogue and debate**; and by the **1780s** it produced **literature and caricatures mocking the royalty**. ★★ **NCERT's qualification**: people read **many kinds of literature including Church and monarchical propaganda**, interpreted things their own way, and *"print did not directly shape their minds, but it did open up the possibility of thinking differently."*
10. ★★ **New nineteenth-century readers**: children (compulsory primary education; a **children's press in France, 1857**; the **Grimms' 1812 collection**, edited to remove what elites thought vulgar); women (**penny magazines**, and novelists **Austen, the Brontës, George Eliot** defining *"a person with will, strength of personality, determination and the power to think"*); and workers (**lending libraries**, a shortened working day, **political tracts and autobiographies**).
11. ★ **Innovations**: metal presses; **Hoe's power-driven cylindrical press at 8,000 sheets an hour**; the **offset press** printing six colours; electric presses; **serialised novels**, the **Shilling Series (1920s)**, the **dust jacket**, and **cheap paperbacks** brought out during the **Depression**.
12. ★★ **India before print** had rich manuscripts in **Sanskrit, Arabic, Persian and vernaculars**, on **palm leaf or handmade paper** — but they were **expensive, fragile and hard to read**, and in **pre-colonial Bengal students learnt only to WRITE from dictation**, so ★ *"many became literate WITHOUT EVER ACTUALLY READING any kinds of texts."*
13. ★★ **Print arrived with Portuguese missionaries at Goa (mid-sixteenth century) — 50 Konkani/Kanara books by 1674, the first Tamil book at Cochin in 1579, the first Malayalam book in 1713, and 32 Tamil texts by Dutch Protestants by 1710**. ★ **From 1780 James Augustus Hickey's Bengal Gazette** — *"open to all, but influenced by none"* — printed **gossip about senior Company officials**, so **Warren Hastings persecuted him** and sponsored loyal papers. The first Indian-run paper was **Gangadhar Bhattacharya's weekly Bengal Gazette**.
14. ★★★ **Reform debates moved into print: Rammohun Roy's Sambad Kaumudi (1821)** against the orthodoxy's commissioned **Samachar Chandrika**; two **Persian papers from 1822** and the **Gujarati Bombay Samachar**; the **ulama's cheap lithographs**, and the **Deoband Seminary (1867)** publishing

thousands of fatwas; and vernacular scripture — the **Ramcharitmanas** printed at Calcutta in 1810, then the **Naval Kishore Press (Lucknow)** and **Shri Venkateshwar Press (Bombay)** from the 1880s. ★ Print **stimulated conflicting opinions AND connected communities** — "creating pan-Indian identities."

15. ★★ **New forms:** the **novel**, lyrics, short stories and essays; a new **visual culture** with **Ravi Varma's mass-circulated images**, **wood engravers beside the letterpresses**, and **cheap prints and calendars in poor homes**; and **from the 1870s caricatures and cartoons**, both imperial and nationalist.
16. ★★★ **Women and print:** liberal families educated women at home and in schools; journals carried **syllabi and reading matter**. ⚠ **Conservative Hindus believed a literate girl would be widowed; Muslims feared corruption by Urdu romances.** Yet a north Indian Muslim girl **secretly learnt Urdu** because she was permitted only **the Arabic Quran she could not understand**; and ★★ **Rashsundari Debi learnt to read in the secrecy of her kitchen and wrote *Amar Jiban* (1876), the first full-length Bengali autobiography.** **Kailashbashini Debi**, then **Tarabai Shinde** and **Pandita Ramabai** in the 1880s, wrote on women's and widows' lives; **Begum Rokeya (1926)** asked "*if men are not led astray once educated, why should women?*" ⚠ But the same presses produced ***Istri Dharm Vichar*** and **Khalsa Tract Society** booklets on wifely obedience, and **Battala** supplied everything from scripture to the scandalous.
17. ★★★ **Print and the poor:** cheap books **sold at Madras crossroads; public libraries from the early twentieth century** (and prestige for their patrons); **Phule's *Gulamgiri* (1871)**, then **Ambedkar and Periyar read all over India**; **Kashibaba's *Chhote Aur Bade Ka Sawal* (1938)** on caste and class, and **Sudarshan Chakr's *Sacchi Kavita***; and **workers' libraries in Bombay and Bangalore**, sponsored by reformers who also wanted to curb drinking.
18. ★★★ **Censorship:** before **1798** the Company's measures targeted **Englishmen** criticising its misrule, for fear of critics **in England**; regulations by the **1820s**; **Bentinck and Macaulay restored freedoms in 1835**; then after **1857** the turn — ★ **the Vernacular Press Act, 1878**, modelled on the **Irish Press Laws**, with **warnings, then seizure of the press and confiscation of machinery**. Nationalist papers **grew anyway**; **Tilak's *Kesari*** on the deported Punjab revolutionaries brought **imprisonment in 1908** and protests across India. In the **First World War, 18 of 22 papers shut rather than furnish securities**; **about 90 newspapers were suppressed in August 1942**. ★★ **Gandhi, 1922: "*The fight for Swaraj... means a fight for this threatened freedom BEFORE ALL ELSE.*"**

Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. The oldest Chinese printed book is — ***the Buddhist Diamond Sutra, AD 868, with six sheets of text and woodcut illustrations.***
2. Gutenberg's printing press was modelled on — ***the olive press, with lead moulds used for casting metal type; the first book was the Bible, about 180 copies in three years.***
3. Consider: (i) 20 million books were printed in Europe in the second half of the fifteenth century. (ii) The Gutenberg press printed 8,000 sheets an hour. (iii) The Index of Prohibited Books began in 1558. — ***(i) and (iii) only. Gutenberg's press printed 250 sheets an hour.***
4. Menocchio was — ***an Italian MILLER, executed after the Inquisition for his own reinterpretation of the Bible.***
5. Match: penny chapbooks / Bibliothèque Bleue / almanac. — ***English pocket books sold by chapmen / French books on poor paper in cheap blue covers / an annual publication of astronomical and***

everyday information.

6. The first printing press in India came to — **Goa, with Portuguese missionaries, in the mid-sixteenth century; the first Tamil book was printed at Cochin in 1579.**
7. Amar Jiban (1876) was — **the first full-length autobiography published in Bengali, written by Rashsundari Debi, who learnt to read in the secrecy of her kitchen.**
8. The Vernacular Press Act was passed in — **1878, modelled on the Irish Press Laws; a seditious report brought a warning, and if ignored, seizure of the press and confiscation of the machinery.**

Mains style

9. What did the spread of print culture in nineteenth-century India mean to (a) women (b) the poor (c) reformers? **(250 words) ★**
10. Why did some people fear the effect of easily available printed books? Choose one example from Europe and one from India. **(250 words) ★**
11. Why did some people in eighteenth-century Europe think that print culture would bring enlightenment and end despotism? **(250 words) ★**
12. Explain how print culture assisted the growth of nationalism in India. **(250 words) ★**
13. Write short notes on: (a) the Gutenberg Press (b) Erasmus's idea of the printed book (c) the Vernacular Press Act. **(150 words)**
14. "Print changed the relationship between ordinary people and authority." Discuss. **(250 words) ★**
15. Trace the history of press censorship in colonial India and assess its significance for the freedom of speech in independent India. **(250 words) ★ — Polity crossover**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Trace print from AD 594 China to Gutenberg, with four dates.
- Say what Gutenberg adapted his press from, and why early printed books imitated manuscripts.
- Explain how a hearing public became a reading public — and why the line blurred.
- Tell the Menocchio story and say what it proves.
- Give Erasmus's objection in his own terms.
- Give the three arguments on print and the French Revolution — and NCERT's qualification.
- Explain "literacy without reading" in pre-colonial Bengal.
- Name Rammohun Roy's paper and the orthodoxy's reply.
- Say what print meant to women, the poor and reformers — two names each.
- Trace censorship from 1798 to 1942, and quote Gandhi's 1922 line.